The Glass

By Eric Bogosian

INTRODUCTION

We are living in challenging times. Turbulence, conflict, change, surprise, challenge and possibility characterize today's world and evoke emotions ranging from excitement, enthusiasm and hope to fear and anxiety. We can look at the world around us with hope and positive thoughts (The Glass is Half Full) or we can see the world through smoke-etched goggles, with negativity and injustice for all (The Glass is Half Empty). How do you see . . . The Glass by Eric Bogosian

Picks up a glass of water, drinks, puts the glass down and addresses the audience.

You know what they say: ''The glass is half empty or the glass is half full?' That's pretty much my philosophy of life. You're born, you live, you die. And somewhere along the line, glass is going to be empty or glass is gonna be full. Empty, full, empty, full, empty, full, empty, full.

I remember when I was a little baby, glass was definitely on the empty side. I didn't have much going for me when I was born. I was only about this big, very small, only weighed about seven pounds. Naked. Crying. Bald. Life was full of challenges: learn to walk, learn to talk, use a spoon, tie my shoe. One thing after the next thing after the next after the next thing after the next!

I mean I'm just this little baby and they cut me no slack. Then it's: "Get out of the house?' Kindergarten, high school, college. I mean it's the same for everybody, right? Learn to drive, get a job, find a place to live, find a love. It's exhausting. And basically what happens is one day you find yourself in a store

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buying a TV set and you realize you've arrived, you're all grown up. You're an adult now. Glass is finally half full. Here's your TV, go home and watch it.

And then you have to make it in this world and if you have any luck at all, you have some modicum of success and then you get to do all these adult things. You get to have a credit card: "Here's your credit card?' Get to go on vacation packages, have a barbecue now and then and um . . . what else? A bigger TV with a remote control, give you a little power in your life.

Get to be condescending to people younger than you. Get to enter the Publishers Clearing House contests, subscribe to lots and lots of stuff you don't really need, trying to put some hope in your life. But all you end up with is stacks of glossy magazines all over your house with little perfume inserts in them that you peel apart so you can sniff the sweet smell of success and remain completely frustrated.

And you do this. You do this for about twenty-five or thirty years and then one day you look in the mirror and you realize your hair's getting a little thin and your stomach's not as flat as it used to be. And from that day on all you can think about is how your hair is falling and your stomach's drooping.

And basically it just gets worse and worse and worse until you're incontinent, mindless and drooling, stuck in a wheelchair in some firetrap senior citizens home next to an interstate highway. And your big thrill of the day is when they're serving strained peaches.

You're sitting in your wheelchair, strapped in so you don't fall over, you're listening to the sound of the traffic whizzing by out on the highway. Maybe you're counting the cars: "Two thousand one, two thousand two, two thousand three –"

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And the attendant brings lunch, which you don't really like, but you like the strained peaches.

And there's this moment, just as that fragment of peach runs down over your old cracked tongue, and for that one moment, for that two or three seconds, everything is good again. Hope is in the air, the glass is half-full once more. But then you start coughing and gagging 'cause you don't have any teeth, you're not that good at swallowing anymore, and the attendant is shouting in your one good ear, "Come on! Come on! You can do better than that! That's no attitude to take!" And [you] think to yourself, if you're capable of thinking anything at all: "DOES DOCTOR KEVORKIAN WORK IN THIS PLACE? I WANT DOCTOR KEVORKIAN!!!"

But that's all kind of in the future for me. I'm pretty happy, things are good.

It can be a beautiful day like today and I can step out into the day and I can think to myself: "This is good -- But even if it is a perfect day and the birds are singing and the sky is blue and I'm holding my four-year-old's hand and everything is perfect, in a way it isn't, because somewhere, and I am reminded of this constantly on the evening news, somebody is suffering like you would not believe!

I mean right now as I say these words, somewhere in Mrica, there is a vast sea of human beings slowly starving to death! A sea of human skeletons dying. They're standing under the same blue sky, the same sun, they're holding their children's hands too.

What can they be thinking as they look down at their kids' bony heads and rib by ribcages and bulging bellies and big brown eyes full of death flies? What can they possibly be thinking? (African voice) "Oh well, the glass is half-empty or the glass is half-full?" Yeah. Right.

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STARVING AFRICANS, STARVING AFRICANS, STARVING AFRICANS, STARVING AFRICANS, STARVING AFRICANS! They spoil everything!
I mean, wait a second. I'd love to help them. And I try, I send them money. But, I can't fix them. I don't even really know where they are. Where are they? Does anybody here know where they are? You don't know where they are. I know where they are. They're on my TV set, every night, 6:30 PM, channel 2.

It all gets very confusing and depressing. And when I get confused and depressed, what I do, I get in my car, I go to the supermarket, I grab a cart and push it around.

I don't know, something about the supermarket makes me feel better. The environment is so clean and orderly-air-conditioned. I mean the name says it all: SUPERMARKET. It's like where Superman goes to shop. And that's the way I feel as I push my cart around, my cape flying behind me, grabbing that bottled water from a melted glacier ("Oh, only five dollars a quart! That's reasonable!"), the mesquite charcoal chips, double-A alkaline batteries for the kids' toys. Blue Jamaican coffee beans from some blue Jamaican! "Oh! Strained peaches on sale! Never know when I might need some of those!"

I keep going until I fill up my cart, then I know I'm finished. I push my cart to the check-out counter. I am reaffirmed in my right to exist in this environment, because I have the cash. This stuff costs a lot of money and I've got it. Makes me feel good. And as I pass the cash over to the checkout girl, I want to say to her: "See, I can pay for it! Now, check it out!"

And as I carry my bags of groceries out to my freshly waxed and detailed automobile sitting in the middle of the parking lot, I'm not confused and depressed anymore. It all makes sense now. I'm serene again. . . because, because I feel deep

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down, I deserve this good life. I work so hard. I work hard at my job, I work hard at my marriage, I work out hard at the gym, I work hard at raising my kids. I MAKE AN EFFORT. I wear sun-block when it's sunny out. I floss my teeth every day. I recycle!

I'm a team player and I play by the rules: Pay the charge cards on time, change my oil every three thousand miles, don't drink when driving. No binging, no drug-taking, no four-in-the-morning-one-more-shot-of-vodka drinking, no speeding, no yelling, no spitting, no cursing, no dancing, no running. Just say "no." That's my life: "Just say no."

You're either on the bus or you're off the bus. But you gotta know the rules: Don't black out, don't shoot up. Remember your social security number and don't disappear. Don't go to India for a year, don't hitchhike down Highway 61, don't walk on the wild side, don't leave your job or you may find the bus has left without you.

And in exchange for all this good behavior I get a brand new car with a factory installed mobile phone. And I can drive my car and talk on the phone and it feels good. I feel like I really belong.

I can come to a stop sign and be blabbing on the phone for three bucks a minute and there's a guy picking bottles out of a trash can for a nickel apiece and it's OK. It's OK. 'Cause I'm doing the best I can, and I know he's doing the best he can.

I want to roll down the window of the car and throw that guy a buck and say: "I'm there for you man, I'm there for you. When the revolution comes, I am on your side."

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Because I am on his side. I'm one of the good guys! I give money to every charity, I wear my red ribbon, I lick stamps for the benefit committee. I have the t-shirts and the tote bags and the coffee mugs to prove my commitment.
I read the morning paper every day, I watch the evening news every night. Lot of painful stories on that news. And I am there for those people. I am there for their pain. "SHOW ME YOUR PAIN, I AM THERE FOR YOU!"

And because I know that I care, I know that I am concerned, my glass isn't just half-full, it's overflowing! Because I love. Love is in my life. I love my wife and kids, I love every single person in the whole world-every single person in Mrica, in Asia, in South America. I wish they were all here right now so I could hug them.

My glass is overflowing because the glass is the glass of life and it is filled with love. And I am drinking with relish from my glass of life. And that love is going down my throat, into my body and it fills my soul. And I drink and I drink, and after awhile I drink so much my bladder gets kind of full and I have to pee.

And oh, here comes that guy from the trash can with his bottle and he needs some love too! Well I've got plenty of love to spare. Bring that bottle over here, dude. Let's fill that right up. And here comes somebody from Zaire with a little tin can and that guy pees into the Zaire guy's can. And here's somebody from Haiti, and somebody from the slums of Rio! We're all drinking and peeing and drinking and peeing and everybody is giving love to everybody else and that's the way the world goes round.

I'm doing the best I can.

Look, a hundred years from now I will just be some bones in a box and so will you and so will that guy picking out the bottles. So what I did in this puny little life of mine will not have made much difference.

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But I will tell you one thing. While I was on this earth, I lived and I loved. . . and I was concerned. And that's what's important.

I am concerned therefore I am.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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